

JAHANGIRNAGAR UNIVERSITY

DEPARTMENT OF ENGLISH

BA (HONOURS) 4TH YEAR FINAL EXAMINATION QUESTION BANK

COURSE CODE: E 401

COURSE TITLE: 20th Century English Literature I

Target Stream: Concentration on Applied
Linguistics & ELT

Batches Included: 42, 43, 44, 46, 47, 48, 49, 50 (Batch 45 missing)

CURRENT SYLLABUS REFERENCE & SCOPE (Session: 2021–2022, Batch 51)

POETRY:

- **William Butler Yeats:** "The Man Who Dreamed of Faeryland," "The Lake Isle of Innisfree," "No Second Troy," "Easter 1916," "The Second Coming," "Leda and the Swan," "Byzantium," "Sailing to Byzantium"
- **Thomas Stearns Eliot:** "The Love Song of J. Alfred Prufrock," *The Waste Land*
- **Benjamin Zephaniah:** "Dis Poetry," "De Rong Song"

DRAMA:

- **George Bernard Shaw:** *Pygmalion*
- **Samuel Beckett:** *Waiting for Godot*

FICTION:

- **Joseph Conrad:** *Heart of Darkness*
- **David Herbert Lawrence:** *Sons and Lovers*
- **James Joyce:** *A Portrait of the Artist as a Young Man*

SECTION A: BROAD QUESTIONS (Essay & Analytical Questions)

Comprehensive broad questions from past final examinations, categorized by prescribed syllabus authors and texts.

1. William Butler Yeats

1. Comment on Yeats's treatment of place and nature in his poems. How are they connected to his personal and Irish identity? [50]
2. How does W.B. Yeats use symbolism and mythological references to explore the tension between chaos and order, as well as the intersection of the temporal and the eternal? Discuss in reference to the poems that you have read. [49]
3. With reference to the poems by the poet from your syllabus, discuss and exemplify the development of W.B. Yeats as a poet. [48]
4. Discuss and exemplify W. B. Yeats' worldview with reference to the poems that you have read. [47]
5. What is Irish about the poetry of W. B. Yeats? Write with reference to any two of his poems that you have read. [46]
6. Make an evaluation of W. B. Yeats as a political poet of Ireland. [44]
7. "The Second Coming" presents one of the most dreadful, and lastingly impressive visions of the tragedy of the Twentieth Century. Discuss. [44]
8. Discuss Yeats' passion for nature in the light of the poems you have studied. [43]
9. "Yeats's style, particularly his use of symbolism, richly conveys a great variety of themes and moods." Discuss. [43]
10. Discuss Yeats as a political poet in the light of the poems you have studied. [42]
11. Explore W.B. Yeats' use of myths in his poetry. [42]

2. Thomas Stearns Eliot

1. T. S. Eliot's poems not only reflect on the dystopian condition of culture, but also offer suggestions of healing. Discuss this based on your reading of his poems. [50]

2. How do T.S. Eliot's "The Love Song of J. Alfred Prufrock" and *The Waste Land* reflect the disillusionment and fragmentation of the modernist era, particularly through their use of alienation and spiritual decay? Discuss. [49]
3. What view of city life does Eliot present in *The Waste Land*? Refer to the poem where necessary. [48]
4. Evaluate *The Waste Land* as a modernist poem. Refer to both the major stylistic and thematic aspects of the poem in this regard. [47]
5. Discuss and exemplify how Eliot presents the predicaments of modern man in "The Love Song of J. Alfred Prufrock." [46]
6. Referencing Eliot's theory of depersonalization as presented in "Tradition and the Individual Talent", evaluate the role of Tiresias in Eliot's *The Waste Land*. [44]
7. Critically comment on the characters of the poem, *The Waste Land*. [43]
8. Analyse the last part of the poem, *The Waste Land*. [43]
9. Make an analysis of the major allusions in T.S. Eliot's poem, *The Waste Land*. [42]

3. Benjamin Zephaniah

1. How does Benjamin Zephaniah define poetry in 'Dis Poetry'? Do you agree with his definition of poetry? [43]
2. Benjamin Zephaniah's conscious mutilation of Queen's English is a fine example of postcolonial writing back to the centre. — Analyse. [42]

4. Joseph Conrad: Heart of Darkness

1. In Conrad's *Heart of Darkness*, both Kurtz and Marlow carry out their colonising missions in similar yet different ways. Do you agree? Justify your position. [50]
2. How does the geo-spatial setting of the Congo River in *Heart of Darkness* consequently affect the psychological condition of the voyagers? Discuss. [49]
3. Why does *Heart of Darkness* have two competing heroes? Make the case for either Marlow or Kurtz as the true "hero" of the book. [48]
4. Do you find *Heart of Darkness* as a racist text? Justify your answer. [47]
5. Does the novel *Heart of Darkness* have a hero? If so, who is it and why? [46]
6. Evaluate the traits that save Marlow from meeting the same end as Kurtz. Why does Marlow feel he has to be loyal to Kurtz? [44]
7. Marlow functions as a moral agent in *Heart of Darkness* for discovering the darkness in our own souls. — Elucidate. [43]
8. Comment on the significance of the geographical setting in *Heart of Darkness*. How is the theme of self-restraint referred to in this regard? [42]

5. James Joyce: A Portrait of the Artist as a Young Man

1. How do the five-chapter divisions of *A Portrait of the Artist as a Young Man* contribute to the formation and resolution of crises? Elaborate. [50]
2. Joyce's *A Portrait of the Artist as a Young Man* reflects an aspiring artist's search for selfhood and inner resistance against sociopolitical barriers. — Justify this statement. [49]
3. What elements of modern fiction do you notice in Joyce's *A Portrait of the Artist as a Young Man*? Discuss in connection with the narrative technique and the major stylistic features of the novel. [48]
4. Discuss the structural pattern of *A Portrait of the Artist as a Young Man*. Refer to Joyce's use of epiphanies in the structural development of the novel. [47]
5. What elements of modern fiction do you notice in Joyce's *A Portrait of the Artist as a Young Man*? Discuss. [46]

6. Define Bildungsroman and Künstlerroman. Can Joyce's *A Portrait of the Artist as a Young Man* be classified as either or both? Justify your answer. [44]
7. Show how *A Portrait of the Artist as a Young Man* traces the development of Stephen as an artist through a series of disengagements from the family, the church, and the country. [43]
8. "Each chapter of *A Portrait of the Artist as a Young Man* concentrates on one of Stephen's major problems and how he finds a way out." — Discuss. [42]

6. David Herbert Lawrence: *Sons and Lovers*

1. In D. H. Lawrence's novel *Sons and Lovers*, how does Paul Morel's attachment to his mother influence both his inner growth and subsequent treatment of women? [50]
2. How does D.H. Lawrence use the setting of the English Midlands to explore themes of industrialization, class and the loss of tradition in *Sons and Lovers*? [49]
3. D. H. Lawrence's *Sons and Lovers* is a psychological novel that deals with the complexities of man-woman relationships. — Justify this statement. [48]
4. Many of the modern English novels are psychological in nature. Justify the statement with reference to *Sons and Lovers*. [47]
5. How does Lawrence portray women in his novel, *Sons and Lovers*? Can Lawrence be called a feminist? Justify your stance. [46]
6. Evaluate the success of D. H. Lawrence in presenting the complexities of male-female relationship in *Sons and Lovers*. [44]
7. Discuss Lawrence's *Sons and Lovers* as a continuous struggle of Paul against the "weakness of being too much his mother's son". [43]
8. How does Lawrence portray women in his novel, *Sons and Lovers*? [42]

7. Samuel Beckett: *Waiting for Godot*

1. In what ways does Samuel Beckett's play *Waiting for Godot* dramatise the themes of nothingness and despair? Discuss with reference to its characters, language, and structure. [50]
2. Evaluate *Waiting for Godot* by Samuel Beckett as an absurdist play. [49]
3. Can *Waiting for Godot* be called an utterly pessimistic play? Refer to the two major characters, their dialogues and the setting of the play in this regard. [48]
4. Why is *Waiting for Godot* called an absurd drama? Discuss. [47]
5. Is *Waiting for Godot* a tragicomedy? Exemplify your stance. [46]
6. Who is Godot? What is your opinion about this 'never-appearing' character? [43]
7. "Waiting for Godot is a story of several pseudo-couples who are inseparable and are projecting various aspects of human nature." — Discuss. [42]

SECTION B: SHORT NOTES & BRIEF ANALYTICAL QUESTIONS

Short explanatory notes and concept-based questions covering prominent characters, symbols, themes, and motifs.

Short Notes Collection

1. Spiritus Mundi (Yeats) [49]
2. Datta, Dayadhvam, Damyata (Eliot) [49]

3. "The horror! The horror!" (Conrad) [49]
4. "We'll hang ourselves" (Beckett) [49]
5. Symbolism in W.B. Yeats' poetry [48]
6. J. Alfred Prufrock in "The Love Song of J. Alfred Prufrock" [48]
7. Religion in *A Portrait of the Artist as a Young Man* [48]
8. The structure of the novel, *Sons and Lovers* [48]
9. Nationalism in W. B. Yeats' poetry [47]
10. Bildungsroman [47]
11. Class conflict in *Sons and Lovers* [47]
12. The boy in *Waiting for Godot* [47]
13. The structure of *The Waste Land* [46]
14. 'Darkness' in Conrad's *Heart of Darkness* [46]
15. Epiphanies in *A Portrait of the Artist As a Young Man* [46]
16. Pozzo and Lucky in *Waiting for Godot* [46]
17. Impressionism in *Heart of Darkness* [44]
18. Stephen's trip to Cork [44]
19. The setting of *Waiting for Godot* [43]
20. "a hawklike man flying sunward above the sea" [43]
21. Baxter Dawes (*Sons and Lovers*) [43]
22. Absurd Theatre [42]
23. The Sepulchral City (*Heart of Darkness*) [42]

SECTION C: EXCERPT EXPLANATIONS & VISUAL / PRACTICAL ANALYSIS

Contextual readings, stanza elucidations, and image-based critical interpretations.

Stanza Analysis: W.B. Yeats' "The Second Coming" [50]

"Surely some revelation is at hand;
 Surely the Second Coming is at hand.
 The Second Coming! Hardly are those words out
 When a vast image out of Spiritus Mundi
 Troubles my sight: somewhere in sands of the desert
 A shape with lion body and the head of a man,
 A gaze blank and pitiless as the sun,
 Is moving its slow thighs, while all about it
 Reel shadows of the indignant desert birds.
 The darkness drops again; but now I know
 That twenty centuries of stony sleep
 Were vexed to nightmare by a rocking cradle,
 And what rough beast, its hour come round at last,
 Slouches towards Bethlehem to be born?"

Questions:

- a) What do you understand by "the Second Coming"?
- b) The above stanza upholds a cosmological pattern about the rise and fall of modern civilisation. Discuss in brief.

Visual Analysis: Joseph Conrad's Heart of Darkness [50]

Stimulus: An illustration depicting Marlow's journey into the Congo interior with torchlight casting eerie shadows amidst deep jungle gloom.

Questions:

- a) What does the lighted torch symbolise in the picture?
- b) How does the image portray the dark horrors of the human psyche? Explain based on your interpretation of the title *Heart of Darkness*.

Explanation with Reference to the Context: Innisfree & Prufrock [44]

Explain with reference to the context:

- a) *"I will arise and go now, and go to Innisfree,
And a small cabin build there, of clay and wattles made;
Nine bean-rows will I have there, a hive for the honey-bee,
And live alone in the bee-loud glade."* (Yeats)

- b) *"In the room the women come and go
Talking of Michelangelo."* (Eliot)

Explanation with Reference to the Context: Prufrock & The Waste Land [43]

Explain with reference to the context:

- a) *"We have lingered in the chambers of the sea
By sea-girls wreathed with seaweed red and brown
Till human voices wake us, and we drown."* ("The Love Song of J. Alfred Prufrock")

- b) *"Datta. Dayadhvam. Damyata. / Shantih shantih shantih"* (*The Waste Land*)

Explanation with Reference to the Context: Heart of Darkness & Sons and Lovers [42]

Explain with reference to the context:

- a) *"The horror! The horror!"* (Conrad: *Heart of Darkness*)
- b) *"And I've never — you know, Paul — I've never had a husband — not really —"* (Lawrence: *Sons and Lovers*)